

SHUTTERSTOCK

of the warrior Khalsa order—and has long been revered as a spiritual centre for Sikhs in Bihar, Jharkhand, Bengal and eastern Uttar Pradesh. The tensions with Takht Hazur Sahib in Nanded, Maharashtra, are another powder keg. Nanded has often bristled at attempts by Amritsar to assert supremacy: on calendar reforms, clergy appointments, even on rituals. It, too, has been known to issue independent edicts.

For the global Sikh diaspora, this is nothing short of disillusionment. The schism isn't just geographic—it's ideological. Sikh preachers from California to Calgary are offering counter-narratives—filling the vacuum left by dithering Takhts. This doctrinal free market may be democratising discourse, but it's also breeding chaos. With no clear line of command, contradictory edicts are now routine. The current stand-off may still be walked back through closed-door parleys. But some damage seems to have been done already. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

CASTE METER 2025

Karnataka undertakes a survey of the state's Scheduled Castes using a digital app developed in-house

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

BY JUNE 1, A NEAR FOUR WEEK-LONG Comprehensive Survey of Scheduled Castes 2025 is set to come to a close in Karnataka. Some 59,000-odd enumerators have fanned out across the state to carry out the door-to-door survey using a digital app. "We wanted it to be on a digital platform from start to end," says Yatish R., who heads the Directorate of Electronic Delivery of Citizen Services, the e-governance department wing which developed the app.

The data was necessary to sub-divide the 17 per cent SC quota into internal categories for a more equitable distribution of reservation benefits among the 101 SC castes in Karnataka. A 2011 census had put their numbers at 2.1 million households but a one-man commission under retired judge H.N. Nagamohan Das recommended a fresh survey, citing "ambiguities" in it that had hindered sub-classification.

The survey had a 42-point questionnaire to be filled up on the mobile phone application using drop-down menus where answers were selected. The state e-governance department's database, Kutumba, came in handy here as it stores information on 11.8 million ration card-holding families (52 million citizens). Kutumba is integrated with all state departments, which means any service provided was automatically synced with the data. So, when an enumerator logged into the app and entered a ration card number, all available details of family members got filled in automatically. Once the form was completed, it was e-signed by the resident who could also log into a portal to review it. Each interview was geo-tagged, the family surveyed issued a unique number and their photo captured. A separate online self-declaration facility was opened up too to ensure maximum coverage. ■

Takeaways

- **State SC survey to lead to a more equitable subdivision of the 17% community quota**
- **For the first time, a mobile digital app used for survey with a 42-point questionnaire**



DIGITAL HAVES The surveyors in Karnataka's Survey of Scheduled Castes fills in details on the special app